When an Education Minister questions Darwin or asserts the miraculous powers of the cow, he is not merely offering a choice between a scientific theory and a faith-based one, he is reminding the public of their allegiance to a total worldview. That worldview embraces a larger political project that prescribes a set of beliefs and behaviours incompatible with science, skepticism and inquiry.

We had a glorious past; wallowing in it and debating it now will only saddle us with a contentious and unproductive present. Indians should take pride in what our forefathers did but resolve to be inspired by them rather than rest on their laurels. We need to use the past as a springboard, not as a battlefield. Only then can we rise above it to create for ourselves a future worthy of our remarkable past.

The BJP is still bent on creating a Hindu state in India. Sadly, this would not be the kind of Hindu state that has made India the scientific superpower of the ancient age, but one plunged in obscurantism and atavistic complacency. It is enough to make one shed a tear. One can only hope that there are no peahens around.

HINDUTVA AND HISTORY

Unsurprisingly, a later period of Indian history, following the Muslim conquests of north India, has become ‘ground zero’ in the battle of narratives between team Hindutva and the pluralists. When, with the publication of my 2016 book *Inglorious Empire: What the British Did to India*, I spoke of 200 years of foreign rule, I found it interesting that at the same time the Hindutva brigade, led by Prime Minister Modi himself, was speaking of 1,200 years of foreign rule. To them, the Muslim rulers of India, whether the Delhi Sultans, the Deccani Sultans or the Mughals (or the hundreds of other Muslims who occupied thrones of greater or lesser importance for several hundred years across the country) were all foreigners. I responded that while the founder of a Muslim dynasty may have well have come to India from abroad, he and his descendants stayed and assimilated in this country, married Hindu women, and immersed themselves in the fortunes of this land; each Mughal Emperor after Babar had less and less connection of blood or allegiance to a foreign country. If they looted or exploited India and